Reading Comprehension: Fiction & Poetry

Year 4 · **Lesson Worksheet**

Worked Examples

Literal Retrieval: Extract: 'The rain hammered on the tin roof all night, and by morning the garden was a lake.' What happened to the garden by morning?

Answer: It had flooded and become like a lake, because of the heavy overnight rain.

Inference & Mood: Extract: 'She stared at the unopened letter for a long time before finally sliding it, unread, into the bottom drawer.' What can you infer about how the character feels about the letter?

Answer: She feels anxious or reluctant to face whatever the letter contains, so she avoids reading it.

Figurative Language: Extract: 'His laughter rang out like a bell across the empty hall.' Identify the simile and explain its effect.

Answer: 'like a bell' compares his laughter to the clear, ringing sound of a bell, emphasising how loudly and clearly it carried through the empty hall.

Literal Retrieval & Vocabulary (15 questions)

1. Extract: 'Mara pressed her palm against the cold glass of the attic window. Dust lay thick on every surface, and a single moth fluttered against the dim bulb overhead. She had not set foot up here since her grandmother died.' What did Mara press her palm against?
2. In the extract above, what does 'fluttered' suggest about the moth's movement? A) It moved in quick, light, unsteady flaps B) It crawled slowly along the floor C) It sat completely still D) It flew in one straight line E) It made a loud buzzing noise
3. According to the extract about Mara, what covered every surface in the attic?
4. Extract: 'The fishing boat lurched as the wave struck its hull. Salt spray stung Old Tomas's eyes, and he gripped the wheel with both hands, knuckles white. Somewhere below deck, his grandson was calling his name.' What struck the boat's hull?
5. In the fishing boat extract, who was calling Old Tomas's name?
6. In the fishing boat extract, what does 'lurched' tell us about how the boat moved? A) It tipped or jolted suddenly and unsteadily B) It glided smoothly forward C) It stopped completely D) It sailed in a perfectly straight line E) It sank slowly
7. Extract: 'The market square buzzed with noise: stallholders shouting their prices, a fiddler sawing out a jig, and somewhere a dog barking at the smell of roasting chestnuts.' Name two things, according to the extract, that could be heard in the market square.
8. In the market square extract, what does 'buzzed' suggest about the market square? A) It was full of busy, lively activity and noise B) It was completely silent C) It was empty of people D) It was dangerous E) It was closing for the day
9. Select ALL that apply, based on the market square extract: which of these are mentioned? A) A fiddler playing a jig B) A dog barking C) The smell of roasting chestnuts D) Rain falling E) A church bell ringing

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10. Poem fragment: 'The wind went whispering through the wheat, / Bowing every golden head; / The sparrows scattered from my feet / And not a single word was said.' According to the poem, what did the wind do to the wheat?

11. In the poem fragment above, what happened to the sparrows?

12. In the poem fragment above, what does 'whispering' suggest about the sound of the wind? A) A soft, quiet, hushed sound B) A loud, roaring sound C) A sharp, cracking sound D) No sound at all E) A high-pitched scream

13. Extract: 'Priya slid into her seat just as the bell rang. Her homework diary was still open on the kitchen table at home, and she had a horrible feeling she had forgotten something important.' What had Priya left open on the kitchen table at home?

14. In the Priya extract, what happened just as she sat down?

15. In the Priya extract, explain in your own words why Priya had 'a horrible feeling'.

Inference, Mood & Character (15 questions)

1. Extract: 'Dad stood by the door with his coat already on, checking his watch every few seconds. When I finally came downstairs he didn't say anything — he just looked at the clock and then at me.' What can you infer about how Dad was feeling while he waited by the door?

2. In the extract above, what does Dad's silence suggest about his mood? A) He is quietly frustrated or irritated B) He is extremely happy C) He has fallen asleep D) He did not notice the narrator arrive E) He is proud of the narrator

3. In the extract above, what two actions show that Dad was anxious about time?

4. Extract: 'The old house creaked with every step Leo took. He told himself it was just the floorboards settling, but his hand still trembled as it hovered over the light switch.' What does Leo's trembling hand suggest about his feelings as he explores the house?

5. What is the overall mood created by the Leo extract? A) Tense and unsettling B) Cheerful and light-hearted C) Calm and peaceful D) Humorous E) Boring

6. In the Leo extract, what explanation does Leo give himself for the creaking sound?

7. Extract: 'Jess slammed her bedroom door so hard the pictures on the landing wall shook. "It's not fair!" she shouted, even though no one was there to hear her.' What can you tell about Jess's character or mood from her actions in this extract?

8. Select ALL that apply, based on the Jess extract: which statements are supported by it? A) Jess is angry. B) Jess believes something is unfair. C) Jess is alone when she shouts. D) Jess is calm and quiet. E) Someone argues back with Jess.

9. In the Jess extract, why might the detail 'even though no one was there to hear her' be included?

10. Poem fragment: 'I walk the shore when no one's near, / The gulls my only company; / The tide comes in without a cheer, / And carries off a part of me.' What does this poem fragment suggest about how the speaker feels?

11. What is the overall mood of the shore poem fragment? A) Lonely and reflective B) Joyful and triumphant C) Angry and aggressive D) Comic E) Frightened

12. According to the shore poem fragment, who or what keeps the speaker company?

13. Extract: 'Grandma never raised her voice. When Tom broke the vase, she simply knelt down, picked up the pieces one by one, and said, "Well, now we know it was never glued very well, don't we?"' What does Grandma's reaction suggest about her character?

14. In the Grandma extract, what did Grandma say after Tom broke the vase?

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15. In the Grandma extract, what does Grandma's comment about the glue suggest she is trying to do?

Figurative Language & Devices (15 questions)

1. Extract: 'The old dog moved slowly and stiffly, like a rusty gate.' Identify the simile and explain what it compares the dog's movement to.
2. Extract: 'The wind howled and tore at the trees.' Which technique is used here? A) simile B) personification C) onomatopoeia only D) rhyme
3. Extract: 'Her anger bubbled up like water in a kettle, quiet at first, then suddenly boiling over.' Identify the simile and explain what it suggests about how her anger develops.
4. Extract: 'The old house creaked and groaned, as if it were tired.' Identify the personification in this extract.
5. Extract: 'The clock ticks on, it never waits, it marches through the garden gates.' Select ALL that apply: which statements about this extract are true? A) The clock is personified as marching. B) The lines use a steady, rhythmic beat. C) The extract contains no figurative language. D) The clock is compared to a soldier using a simile.
6. Extract: 'Marcus ran so fast his legs felt like they were on fire.' Identify the simile used in this extract.
7. Extract: 'Grief sat heavily on her shoulders, like a sack of stones.' Identify the simile and explain what it compares grief to.
8. Extract: 'The city never sleeps.' Which technique is used, and what does it suggest? A) Personification, suggesting the city is always busy and active B) Simile, comparing the city to a person C) Onomatopoeia, imitating a sound D) Rhyme, linking two lines together
9. Extract: 'The branches, like gnarled old hands, reached out over the lane.' Identify the simile used here.
10. Extract: 'Silence settled over the house like a heavy blanket.' What does this simile suggest about the silence? A) It felt heavy, thick and almost suffocating B) It was barely noticeable C) It was replaced by loud noise D) It lasted only a second
11. Extract: 'The waves clawed at the cliff, patient and relentless.' Identify the personification and explain its effect.
12. Extract: 'The old oak had seen a hundred summers. Its branches reached out over the lane as though trying to shelter every traveller who passed.' Select ALL that apply: which statements are supported by this extract? A) The tree is personified as trying to shelter travellers. B) The tree is very old. C) The tree has no branches. D) The extract uses no figurative language.
13. Extract: 'Her voice was music to his ears.' Identify the metaphor used in this extract and explain what it suggests.
14. Poem fragment: 'The wind went whispering through the wheat, bowing every golden head.' What does 'whispering' suggest about the sound of the wind?
15. Extract: 'Time crept by as she waited.' Identify the technique used and explain its effect.

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